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Ethical reflections on becoming teachers

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ABSTRACT
This study analyzes narratives written in a culminating graduate seminar on reflective practice by 36 new secondary teachers who were asked to consider their moral beliefs, moral values and system of ethics as they reflected on their recent student teaching experiences. The findings explore how the participants depicted their constructed moral identities and felt obligated to critically reflect on them, affirmed values that guided their practice, and desired to be role models. Implications include attending to novice teachers' moral identity development, infusing moral language into teacher education and recognizing teachers' moral purposes, introducing curriculum to cultivate moral imagination, and helping teachers to realize their potential as moral agents by preparing them to become moral educators. The study also suggests the need to allow for broader ethical and political conceptions of the moral dimensions of teaching.

KEYWORDS
Critical reflection; moral agent; moral dimensions of teaching; moral identity; teacher education

Introduction

A number of researchers studying the moral dimensions of teaching lament the dearth of educators' 'moral language' or 'moral vocabulary' and lack of complex understanding of ethics, moral agency and the moral nature of their work (Bergem, 1992; Sockett & LePage, 2002). They also note that critical ethical reflection does not come naturally to teachers or teacher candidates (Bruster & Peterson, 2013; Willemse, Lunenberg, & Korthagen, 2008) and that the school environment where technical issues take precedence over moral concerns 'blinds teachers to the moral dimensions of their practice' (Huebner, 1996, p. 268). Scholarship of this bent reveals a deficit model that characterizes teachers as lacking in ability to understand or articulate complex ethical aims and/or not having the imagination or fortitude to be moral agents in ethically insolvent educational institutions.

Yet other researchers recognize that the teaching profession attracts individuals who have altruistic purposes (Brookhart & Freeman, 1992; Joseph & Green, 1986), care about the future of children and adolescents (Lin, Shi, Wang, Zhang, & Hui, 2012) and desire to make moral contributions to their students and society (Sanger & Osguthorpe, 2013b). Some argue that the problem is not teachers' deficiencies but that teacher education disregards teachers as moral beings (Joseph, 2003; Richardson & Watt, 2005), making for a 'moral vacuum' that

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is 'demoralizing' to teachers and those becoming teachers (Sanger & Osguthorpe, 2013b, p. 52). Such views speak to the perspective that teachers and teaching candidates have deep moral impulses that attract individuals to the profession and that teachers, as adult learners, search for 'moral meaning' in their lives (Brookfield, 1998).

In response to the above dichotomy about teachers' moral capabilities, the impetus for this study was the desire to learn how novice teachers understand the moral dimensions of teaching—how they represent their personal ethics and might imagine their moral roles and responsibilities. Eventual analysis of the participants' reflections casts light on their perceptions of moral identity and identity development, moral values guiding practice, and roles as moral agents.

The study

This study is an analysis of beginning teachers' narratives, cultivated in a culminating graduate seminar on reflective practice, on ethical reflections pertaining to their recent student teaching experiences. The researcher was the seminar's instructor and had previously taught a curriculum studies course to the same participants (two cohorts) in the first quarter of their program. The study's mode of inquiry stems from the perspective of reflective writing as an important data source for qualitative research (Jasper, 2005). The data are narratives of 'authentic experiences' (Griffin, 2003, p. 208), retrospective autobiographical narratives about the influence of morality and ethics on practice.

During the seminar, the new teachers developed their narratives over time and concurrently read about reflection and examples of reflective practice. Although they often referred to seminar readings, the narratives permitted them 'to use their own experiences from which to drive meaning'; such writing lessened the possibility of 'parroting back' to meet instructors' expectations (Johnson, 2008, p. 442). The directions for the assigned writing allowed for both the articulation of unexamined moral beliefs as well as more reflective ethical deliberation—'a conscious stepping back and reflecting on morality' (Jeong & Han, 2013, p. 45). Participants were not asked for immediate responses, as might happen in a survey or an interview, or to respond to hypothetical situations conceivably unrelated to their lives or situations. Also, they were not required to consider moral identity, moral obligations or responsibilities as moral agents.

Participants

The participants (given pseudonyms in this study) were 36 new secondary teachers from two consecutive cohorts. (A total of 45 teachers were in both cohorts but nine did not give research consent.) These teachers were older than typical recent college graduates and many were career changers with considerable work experience in a variety of fields. At the time of each culminating seminar, 11% of the participants were in the 22–25-year age range, 36% were aged 26–30, 42% were aged 31–39 and 11% were aged 40–52. Approximately two-thirds of the participants were female and one-third male; this population included several non-white ethnicities but most of the teachers were of European American descent.

Three-fourths of the participants completed student teaching in high schools and one-fourth in middle schools—in the subject areas of English, language arts, humanities, history, social studies, mathematics and science. In identifying their educational philosophies,

approximately 40% of the teachers described their curricular orientation as constructivist and another 40% as critical (either critical pedagogy or a hybrid, e.g. critical constructivist, critical democratic); the remainder identified themselves in the liberal arts, holistic or democratic curricular traditions. During the quarter of the culminating seminar, the teachers worked as substitute teachers and interviewed for permanent positions.

Context

The reflections were written toward the end of a masters/secondary certification program that highlights constructivist pedagogy, community-based learning and social justice. Throughout the program, teaching candidates were asked to reflect on their learning; in one core course in the second quarter of the program, they reflected on their values as influenced by families and cultures by writing autoethnographies. The program did not offer specific classes on ethics or professional ethics (aside from a state-required course on recognizing and preventing abuse), the moral dimensions of teaching or moral education. In addition, the teachers did not study ethics or consider definitions of morality and ethics in the culminating seminar.

The seminar was created for the purpose of writing the Reflective Practice Portfolio to illustrate and reflect upon evidence of student teaching accomplishments. Several readings were assigned weekly for the purpose of deepening understanding of reflection. Reading topics included the nature of reflection, types of teacher reflection, teacher uncertainty, presence in teaching, critical understanding of diverse students' perspectives, ethical reflection, and teacher images and archetypes. During the culminating seminar, the new teachers wrote about *five realms of reflection*: their educational *philosophy*; the *context* of their classrooms and schools in student teaching; *professional knowledge*; *ethics*; and *identity*. The two assigned readings relating to ethical reflection focused on the concepts of teacher tact and 'moral intuitiveness' (van Manen, 1995, p. 44) and teachers' need for 'moral wide-awakeness', defined as 'attentiveness to the moral dimensions of existence', cognizance of their own values, and 'breaking with the mechanical life' (Greene, 1978a, pp. 46–47).

Mindful of the importance of creating an environment that encourages reflection (see Boud & Walker, 1998), the program faculty decided that the culminating seminar would be a credit/no credit course; the instructor did not grade the reflections. Additionally, in the seminar participants shared excerpts from their writing in small groups and in whole-class discussion and had time to develop drafts and revisions before the final portfolio was due. Instructor and peer feedback focused on three questions: did the reflections connect to student teaching experiences, especially relating to actual incidents or stories? Were there connections to academic learning within their graduate studies? And were the ideas within one section better suited to another realm of reflection? The instructor also made suggestions on editing for clarity. Evaluative comments about the worth of the reflections were not given and critique was never about the teachers' beliefs or decisions.

Data

To avoid both extremes when cultivating reflection—insisting on formal step-by-step instructions or providing few or no directions (Boud & Walker, 1998)—the narratives were designed to be semi-structured; the participants were given a specific focus for all

sections (the five realms) but had considerable choice about content. The writing prompt for ethical reflections was: *to reflect on your moral beliefs, values, and system of ethics that influence your practice*. On average, the ethical reflection narratives were 1270 words in length. After both cohorts completed the seminar, the ethical reflections were analyzed as a whole to capture the participants' overall values and concerns.

Data analysis

Interpretation of data was based on qualitative content analysis (Krippendorff, 1989; Stemler, 2001), which names 'concepts or categories describing the phenomenon' for the purpose of 'identifying core meanings' (Osguthorpe & Sanger, 2013, p. 182), to provide 'new insights' and to allow for replication of studies (Elo & Kyngäs, 2008, p. 108). This approach to data analysis primarily is inductive and aims to 'examine meanings, themes and patterns' (Zhang & Wildemuth, 2009, p. 1) rather than 'generating or discovering theory' (Thomas, 2006, p. 241).

Informed by the moral dimensions of teaching literature, the researcher began data analysis by noting concepts and experiences found in the narratives. In subsequent analyses of the writing, codes were developed and later refined, and then the researcher coded the data. Codes were applied to passages as brief as a clause and as long as a succession of sentences and, as needed, multiple codes occasionally were applied to the same passage. The next step of the data analysis was to establish interrater reliability by having two scholars with qualitative research expertise each code approximately one-half of the reflective writing transcripts. One scholar validated the list of established codes by finding examples in the narratives. The second scholar, familiar with the moral dimensions of teaching literature, validated the codes but also noted the relevance to the literature of several emergent and infrequent codes. The final data analysis incorporated the second scholar's recommendations.

Calculations then were made about occurrences of codes within the data (with code frequency referring to participants' mention of a code, not to how many times a code appeared in individuals' reflective writing). To explain the data, four labels were created to delineate occurrences. When a code emerged in two-thirds or more of the participants' writing, it was labeled a *common* code. A *prevalent* code was a label for occurrences in one-half to just under two-thirds of the transcripts; an *emergent* code appeared in one-third to just under one-half; and an *infrequent* code appeared in less than one-third of the transcripts (see Table 1).

Development of an organizational framework to characterize the data is explained by this study's utilization of an inductive approach in which 'themes and categories emerge from the data through the researcher's careful examination and constant comparison' (Zhang & Wildemuth, 2009, p. 2). In this way, the final step of data analysis was to group the codes into core categories of meaning. Eventually three separate yet inter-related categories emerged from the data: moral identity, moral values guiding practice, and moral agent roles. Discussion of the findings centers on common and prevalent codes with some attention to emergent and infrequent codes when relevant to the literature.

Limitations

Limitations to this research include lack of documentation of spontaneous use of moral language because the participants were explicitly prompted to write about their moral

Table 1. Codes in narratives.

Teachers' moral identities	
Affirmation of core ethical values	Prevalent
Moral obligations/responsibilities	Prevalent
Critical reflection on ethics	Prevalent
Ethics as evolving	Emergent
Professional ethics	Infrequent
Moral values guiding practice	
Respect	Common
Equity	Common
Caring	Prevalent
Relationship	Prevalent
Safety	Prevalent
Fairness	Emergent
Trust	Emergent
Empathy	Emergent
Values embedded in practice	Emergent
Teachers as moral agents	
Role models	Prevalent
Moral leadership	Emergent
Moral intervention/taking a stand	Emergent
Experiencing moral dilemmas	Emergent
Fostering students' critical reflection	Emergent
Helping students to become moral people	Infrequent

Occurrence	Participants
Common	2/3 or more
Prevalent	1/2 to 2/3
Emergent	1/3 to 1/2
Infrequent	Less than 1/3

beliefs, values and systems of ethics. Also, the data on moral agent actions in classrooms were based only on self-reported descriptions. Furthermore, no information was available about the teachers' viewpoints about the moral dimensions of teaching before they began graduate studies and thus the study could not portray changes during and/or at the end of the program or the influences of course readings, discussions and reflective writing. Finally, this study focused on narratives by graduate-level participants generally older than the young adults who typically are in teacher preparation programs; how adult perspectives and life experiences informed their reflections could not be ascertained.

Moral identity

Scholarship on the moral dimensions of teaching suggests that one's self-concept as a moral person is crucial to the development of a teacher as an ethical practitioner. Moral identity is important to an individual's overall identity—to the concept of self (Hardy & Carlo, 2011; Jeong & Han, 2013)—and is 'the source of a moral imperative … an inner need to do the morally right thing' (Mustakova-Possardt, 2004, pp. 253–254). Secondly, moral identity can be understood not just as an end product of ethical knowledge but as a dynamic construct of ethical knowledge and self-formation. Moral identity reveals 'our being and action at a given time and place' (Husu & Tirri, 2003, p. 347) with the self in continuous formation (Greene, 1978b). Therefore a telling way to think about teachers constructing their moral identities is to imagine this process both ethically and politically as 'identity work' (Clarke, 2009, p. 186) in which 'our identities are thus partly given yet they are also something that has to be achieved' (p. 187).

The moral dimension of teaching literature, as supported by adult learning research, posits critical reflection's important role in moral learning and the formation of teachers' moral identities (Armon, 1998; Brookfield, 1998; Sockett & LePage, 2002) and that 'identity work and ethics are inextricably linked to the operation of critique' (Clarke, 2009, p. 195). Critical reflection has the potential to help individuals to develop ethical values rather than operating on the basis of unexamined moral beliefs by allowing reflection on morality (Hinman, 2012). In this way, individuals who engage in critical reflection examine their moral beliefs and thoughtfully craft ethical principles. Moreover, informed by their ethical knowledge, teachers can then do moral critique of existing social and political conditions influencing schooling. Critical reflection also contributes to moral learning by allowing adults to recognize and grapple with moral dilemmas rather than viewing moral issues and decisions as simplistic or absolute as moral learning moves individuals to question ethical certainty and to become aware of moral complexity. Thus, experiencing ethical dilemmas can stimulate reflection leading to moral learning and growth (Brookfield, 1998) when teachers identify their conundrums and realize the myriad of moral choices and issues involved in their decisions.

In the majority of the narratives, the teachers articulated aspects of moral identity as characterized in the literature on the moral dimensions of teaching and adult moral development. A prevalent code is affirmation of core moral values whereas ethics as evolving is an emergent code. Other prevalent codes include moral obligation and belief that critical reflection is integral to teachers' moral development. Very few teachers considered professional ethics as influencing their moral identity.

More than half of the participants affirmed core moral values and wrote about the importance of possessing an ethical system to guide their teaching practice:

> In bringing my whole self to the classroom I recognize and acknowledge that my morals, beliefs and values are tightly interwoven and that subtexts to my practice exist. (Selena, Female, High School, English)

In contrast, approximately one-third of the participants did not write about having core values integral to their identities but interpreted their ethics as fluid or evolving:

> I believe there is no single universal guideline or set of ethical norms, set in the past, to which everyone must adhere. This does not mean that I do not believe in right or wrong; rather, I feel that in the classroom and in democracy we create our own concept of right and wrong through our active membership in society. (Darin, Male, High School, English)

A majority of the participants explored their moral identities through discourse on moral obligations and responsibilities, suggesting that their holding of values meant intensely felt and deeply rooted commitments. Such reflections depict a coherent sense of the teacher as an ethical person and educator:

> I recognize that I am potentially one of the primary forces for good in my students' lives and as such, I have a moral obligation to give my 'full attention to life and its requirements' …. To me this means living my life in such a way that I am being consistent in and out of the classroom. (Caroline, Female, Middle School, History and English)

Several participants made connections to Dewey's (1909, p. 7) declaration that there are not 'two sets of ethical principles' for life and school, stating that their personal morality and ethics as teachers should be consistent.

Nearly all participants, including the teachers who avowed a set of core principles, conveyed their ethics as constructed over time, mediated by their experiences and education,

and influenced—but not directly bequeathed—by the moral teachings of families, religions and cultures.

> I see my ethics as a teacher as an intrinsic element because teachers must connect ethics to moral principles that we have developed throughout our entire lives. I am of the belief that morals cannot simply be instilled, but must be experienced. (Bonita, Female, High School, Social Studies)

> The moral philosophy that I bring to my teaching is obviously a complex product of my personal upbringing, the times in which I live, and the interpretation of life that I have developed through study and experience over the last twenty years. (Isaac, Male, High School, Mathematics)

So, too, teachers who affirmed core ethical beliefs expressed expectation of their continual moral development and recounted experiences of moral learning:

> As a new teacher, I expect that my values in educating will continue to develop over time as I encounter new people and new situations. Despite this expected evolution, I do have a base with which to consider now the systems of ethics that influence my practice. (Lindsey, Female, High School, Mathematics)

Yet participants generally did not regard professional ethical principles as influencing their moral identities. Only several teachers explicitly discussed professional ethics but did so in discordant ways. Two wrote that professional ethics set high standards for them to 'guide practice' and 'to ensure that my practice is sound and full of integrity'. One participant noted that professional ethics should be scrutinized and another insisted that professional ethics are inadequate:

> Ethics and professionalism should go hand-in-hand in order to promote effective welcoming learning environments, but they basically set a minimum standard for me and only begin to address the multitude of other values which I and other teachers strive to live by … to name a few: empathy, trust, sincerity, compassion and even sympathy once you are faced with a classroom full of children in varying cognitive and emotional states. (Richard, Male, High School, Science)

However, the narratives do not illuminate why participants seldom discussed professional ethics—if they had little knowledge of professional ethical codes or if they perceived them as inadequate guides for navigating the intricate moral worlds of classrooms and relationships.

Finally, apropos of narratives written for a course on reflective practice, a prevalent code is critical reflection on ethics. Somewhat more than one-half of the teachers wrote that they must examine their moral identities and often expressed this viewpoint as a deeply felt commitment:

> I am obligated—I am *morally* obligated—to reflect on every moral choice I make in order to make myself as conscious as possible of where I stand …. Through this awareness of self, we are more likely to develop a system of values that is more consistent than chaotic. As educators and models of the value systems that we choose to live by, we are obligated to examine ourselves, our thoughts and our actions. (Bruce, Male, High School, Mathematics)

Whereas some participants more generally explained that critical reflection is important to their professional growth, others believed that critical reflection made them more ethical because through this process they could examine their biases, consider if their moral beliefs and actions were congruent, and reflect upon themselves as role models:

> I have to think about and examine the choices I make in everyday life, turning the seemingly mundane decisions I make daily into a study of ethical inquiry …. I reflect in order to ensure that the behavior I am modeling shows students how to treat others with respect and dignity. (Gwen, Female, High School, English)

In sum, the teachers' recognition of their moral identities—as described by core moral values and obligations as well as their awareness that their identities develop over time—are key findings in this study. Another is the teachers' insistence that to be ethical educators, moral identity must be interrogated.

Moral values guiding practice

In the moral dimensions of teaching literature, scholars maintain that teachers become ethical educators by affirming 'core principles relating to virtues such as honesty, justice, fairness, care, empathy, integrity, courage, respect, and responsibility' (Campbell, 2006, p. 32). Others write that it is ethics—'a system of ideals, values, and norms'—that guide teachers as human beings and as practitioners (Aloni, 2008, p. 149) and that 'recognition of principles' allows teachers to be professionals and not merely have an occupation (Carr, 2006, p. 173). Moreover, moral values are woven into the daily life of classrooms and schools, often through what teachers emphasize in the explicit and implicit curriculum as well as in their relationships with students (Buzzelli & Johnston, 2002; Colnerud, 2006).

As explicitly prompted, nearly all of the teachers wrote about moral values that influence their practice. Analysis of the narratives makes clear that the teachers seldom discussed more individualistic moral values such as honesty and integrity; rather they focused on values that sustain moral classrooms as well as respectful and caring relationships with students. Common codes are respect and equity; prevalent codes are caring, relationship and safety. The emergent codes include fairness, trust, empathy and moral values embedded in practice.

More than four-fifths of the participants discussed respect as a core ethical value and as a guide to creating classroom cultures:

> My core value, the golden rule, to treat others in a way that you would want to be treated, for me, boils down to the value of respect. Mutual respect between students and teacher requires adults to see the students as people and unique individuals, which in turn leads to seeing them as valued resources with worthwhile ideas and skills. It also requires students to see the teacher as a person in need of encouragement and nurturing just like they do …. So much is encompassed within this value of respect that little else is needed. (Grace, Female, High School, Mathematics)

Also, more than two-thirds of the participants wrote about equity as an ethical value influencing their practice, some linking equity to respect:

> One of the most important qualities of respect is a commitment to equity. This idea goes beyond the simple idea of fairness and instead addresses students' true needs for learning and ultimately allows me as a teacher to respect those needs …. It is my responsibility as an educator to treat these students with respect and provide for them what they need to be successful. (Barbara, Female, High School, Mathematics)

In addition, more than one-half of the participants named the values of caring and relationship—how they try to care for students and create classroom cultures in which students care for others:

> I am committed to fostering a sense of care within my classroom communities. As educational reform continues to center around accountability and standardization which tends to promote competition and individualism, it is important that I emphasize interdependence and caring for others so that my students and colleagues can extend this within their greater communities and ultimately, society. (Danika, Female, Middle School, Social Studies)

In a similar vein, teachers wrote about the importance of classrooms in which students feel safe physically and emotionally:

> [We as] 'educators have the responsibility to make school a safe place by helping students understand the consequences of the choices they make' …. This can take the form of stepping in when I see bullying occurring, or making a stand against racism and prejudice. (Patricia, Female, Middle School, English and Language Arts)

As a final point about values, even though many of the participants described examples of how they perceived moral values embedded in their practice, just one-third of the teachers acknowledged this phenomenon outright:

> Every action I make has 'normative significance' within the classroom. My actions, what I choose to acknowledge or to ignore, contribute to the environment in the classroom and set the expectations of the classroom community. Those actions determine who is included in or excluded from the community and show my beliefs and attitudes toward different students. (Gwen, Female, High School, English)

Such accounts illustrate that some of the teachers were aware that curricular decisions, approaches to discipline and the making of classroom cultures reflect their moral values.

Moral agent roles

Scholars writing about the moral dimensions of teaching depict teachers as moral agents. Such educators are consciousness of 'their moral agent state of being' (Campbell, 2008, p. 603) involving 'deep awareness of the significance of one's choices and how those choices influence the development and well-being of others' (Buzzelli & Johnston, 2002, p. 120). Teachers as moral agents likewise are described as having an important role in fostering students' moral and intellectual development (Bergem, 1990) and in other ways serving as moral educators (Aloni, 2008; Campbell, 2003), 'both by example or modeling and by deliberate instruction' (Campbell, 2006, p. 32). Moreover, scholars suggest that teachers who believe they should be moral agents may experience ethical dilemmas about how to serve the best interests of children and when they encounter barriers to living according to their moral imperatives (Pantić & Wubbels, 2012; Shapira-Lishchinsky, 2011).

In this study there is only one prevalent code relating to teachers as moral agents—the participants' perception of themselves as moral role models. But the narratives illustrate that these teachers did not imagine themselves as role models in the same way. Some wrote that as role models they should demonstrate their moral values in the classroom, others explained that they should be models of moral consciousness and sensitivity, while others asserted that modeling critical thinking is a teacher's moral responsibility.

Teachers who recognized their roles as moral agents most often explained how they must set examples of the moral values they espouse:

> I strive to be a role model for my students, not just as a person who loves math and has found a way to use it in everyday life, but as a thoughtful individual who makes careful decisions. I hope that my students see the care and concern that I put into everything I do, and use me as an example of the kind of person they want to grow to become. (Hannah, Female, High School, Mathematics)

Others wrote about being role models of moral consciousness by demonstrating their sensitivity to ethical concerns and willingness to critique institutions and society.

> Maxine Greene argues that teachers have the responsibility of initiating their students into moral consciousness, which for her means an awareness that individuals can shake off the torpor of everyday banality and indifference, and find alternatives to the forms of institutional and social conformity that dominate our modern lives. (Isaac, Male, High School, Mathematics)

And although a number of teachers emphasized being intellectual role models as critical thinkers rather than being examples of moral consciousness, they considered it their moral obligation to show students what it means to be wide-awake and critically concerned about the world around them:

> I believe that if my goal as a teacher is to inspire my students in a way that extends beyond simply helping them to read and write better, I too have an obligation to actively model my commitment to being a lifelong learner. Ultimately, I wish to guide my students in engaging ideas and give them the habits of mind to be critical consumers of information in the world …. (Vincent, Male, High School, Language Arts and Social Studies)

Nonetheless, some participants thought of themselves as moral agents in other ways than as role models. Within descriptions of these teachers' moral values, the narratives reveal how some believed they must act on their moral values, especially to respect and care for students:

> I believe that as a teacher it is my responsibility to protect the needs of the oppressed. Bullying in schools is on the rise and I believe it is wrong to stand by as a teacher and do nothing …. As a teacher, I refuse to stand by and watch students treating each other unkindly. (Barbara, Female, High School, Mathematics)

However, explicit recognition of moral intervention and leadership were emergent codes articulated by approximately one-third of the participants.

The narratives also portray the participants' desire to be moral agents expressed through their stories about moral dilemmas in teaching—an emergent but almost prevalent code. Nearly one-half of the participants wrote extensively about such conundrums, often about meeting students' needs. These reflections reveal how the teachers felt conflicted about how to live in accordance with their moral values while coping as well as they could despite circumstances that challenged them as novices. One such narrative illustrates the nature of dilemmas and how awareness of quandaries clarifies a teacher's ethics:

> The moral and ethical beliefs of my practice have continually revealed themselves through 'dilemmas' I experienced during my student teaching experience both in the classroom and working with various staff. A majority of the dilemmas I faced involved providing equitable resources for my special needs population and my English language learners. Each moment I stopped and paused about what I was teaching or planning and how it would affect each of these populations, I realized I was defining my system of ethics as a professional. (William, Male, High School, History)

Also, several participants realized the student teaching situation itself provoked dilemmas that challenged their ability to be moral agents and compromised their moral integrity:

> If [teachers are] 'awake' and utilizing their moral agency and considering the moral dimensions of decisions, since they are an example for the students, this will have a positive impact. On the other hand, if teachers just do their job and play their role without weighing moral dimensions of their choices, that would have a detrimental effect on their students' process of moral learning …. That is the disconnect I felt while student teaching. I was just playing the role of a passive teacher in the system (appropriate for the situation of student teaching), and I was not showing the students an example of what it means to be 'moral' or 'awake'. (Cynthia, Female, High School, Social Studies)

Lastly, depictions of the teachers as moral agents who foster their students' moral development occurred in the reflections, but not as common or prevalent codes. An emergent code in the narratives is fostering students' critical reflection; somewhat more than one-third of the participants discussed teaching critical reflection and stimulating in students a moral consciousness. However, the goal of helping students to become moral people—developing moral character or teaching students to act ethically—was discussed by just one-fourth of the teachers. Thus, in their reflections on ethics the participants infrequently wrote about specific moral education approaches. Nevertheless, it is clear that overall these teachers perceived themselves as moral influences by trying to live consistently with their personal values and by creating classroom cultures of respect, equity, caring and relationship

Conclusions and implications

In their narratives the participants explored their moral identities and reflected on how these identities were formed through experience; they also articulated core ethical values and described how they perceived themselves as moral agents. Analysis of the 36 teachers' ethical reflections reveals that these novice educators did not view themselves merely as technicians (Sockett, 1996) or classroom managers who desire to 'produce nice students who do as they are told and behave in accordance with school and classroom rules' (Thornberg, 2008, p. 1793). Instead, they reflected deeply upon their moral obligations as teachers and the moral nature of their profession. Once more, it is apparent from the connections they made to course readings that the participants embraced ideas relating to moral sensitivity and capacity.

In several ways this study contributes to research on the moral dimensions of teaching. It challenges claims that teachers neither perceive the profoundly moral nature of their work nor employ a robust moral language to describe their practice. It also reveals how teachers are aware of their constructed moral identities (Clarke, 2009; Mustakova-Possardt, 2004), are cognizant of their moral learning (Armon, 1998; Brookfield, 1995) and believe in the need for critical reflection on morality (Jay & Johnson, 2002). This study also corroborates previous research by confirming that teachers typically value respect and caring (Campbell, 2003; Joseph & Efron, 1993; Narvaez & Lapsley, 2008), portray themselves as role models (Bergem, 1992; Campbell, 2003; Colnerud, 2006; Sanger & Osguthorpe, 2013a) and do not appear to have a strong knowledge base of moral education strategies (Sanger & Osguthorpe, 2011; Thornberg, 2008). Several of these findings have implications for teacher education.

The participants' extensive reflections on their moral identities, values and perceptions of themselves as role models suggest that teacher education programs need not be 'reticent' in attending to the 'moral work of teaching' (Sanger & Osguthorpe, 2013b, p. 189). Rather, teacher educators should help candidates 'to cultivate ethical knowledge' and to understand the 'layered nuances of classroom and school life in terms of their moral and ethical significance' (Campbell, 2006, p. 32). Moral language and ethical inquiry can be infused into the education of teachers by encouraging reflection and self-knowledge (Schussler, Stooksberry, & Bercaw, 2010, p. 351). For instance, intentional consideration of moral identity as a 'conceptualization of one's ideal self' (de Ruyter & Steutel, 2013, p. 182) and affirmation of the moral purposes that attract individuals to the teaching profession should enter into discussions of teaching decisions and dilemmas. In addition, teacher preparation programs can infuse curricula with rich sources of literature to spark intellectual engagement and

enhance moral imagination. Such teacher education practices reaffirm teaching as a moral endeavor and mitigate the technical paradigm focused on standardized testing for students and performance objectives for teachers.

Moreover, the participants' portrayal of their moral identities as not fixed but in formation suggests another reason for infusion of moral language into teacher education: moral identity 'can change over time' and be influenced by 'organizational contexts' (Weaver, 2006, pp. 347, 351). While amoral environments—such as demoralized, cynical school cultures—may eventually affect teachers' moral identities for the worse, ethically committed teacher education may inspire educators to 'seek critical self awareness' (Sanger & Osguthorpe, 2011, p. 576) and to view themselves as moral learners committed to ongoing questioning of the ethics of their decisions and of the environments in which they teach. Critical ethical reflection makes it possible for teachers to recognize and challenge unethical school cultures.

Another implication stems from the participants' expression of a 'societally focused moral sensibility' (Chubbuck, Burant, & Whipp, 2007, pp. 117–118) as witnessed by their integration of sociopolitical concerns about equity, diversity and oppression into their discussions. Indeed, the narratives reveal the new teachers' strong sense of moral obligation when contemplating their roles in creating equitable classrooms. Some scholars argue that professional ethics should be 'grounded in humanism and critical pedagogy, giving priority to the enhancement of human welfare, development, and dignity' (Aloni, 2008, p. 151). This position emphasizes teachers' engagement with 'the wider ethical and political conversation about the ultimate moral and social purposes of education' (Carr, 2006, p. 176) toward the goals of social justice and democracy (Sleeter, 2008; Zeichner, 2006). In response to the concern about teachers having a narrow conception of the moral nature of teaching, teacher education can encourage novices to understand that their identities are 'ethical and political' (Clarke, 2009, p. 189). By envisioning a more expansive vision of the moral dimensions of teaching, teacher education can encourage new teachers to contemplate 'the ways in which schooling and one's own teaching contribute or fail to contribute to a just and humane society' (Adler, 1991, p. 142).

Finally, the narratives illustrate that these teachers perceived themselves as having crucial moral roles and commitments, yet they seldom explicitly wrote about teaching to foster students' moral development. Researchers posit that it is imperative to help new teachers appreciate the complexity of the moral realm but also to learn how to become moral educators (Joseph, 2003; Sanger & Osguthorpe, 2011; Thornberg, 2008). Such teacher education practices prepare teachers to become 'intentional and wise in praxis' and to learn how to be more deliberate in influencing the 'character formation' of their students (Narvaez & Lapsley, 2008, p. 169). As follows, this study suggests that even teachers who have a strong sense of their moral identities and clear understanding of the moral nature of teaching may have little knowledge about how to realize their full potential as moral agents. Teacher education especially has a responsibility to novice educators who want to be 'forces for good' to gain the expertise to become informed and competent moral educators.

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